

Nokia, Microsoft join hands to take on Android, iOS

Nokia and Microsoft, in a joint press statement, have announced plans to join hands to combat the growing popularity of Android and iPhone devices among smartphone consumers. While the exact details of the deal are still being worked out, the companies have outlined a few important points:

- Nokia will adopt Windows Phone as its primary smartphone strategy, innovating on top of the platform in areas such as imaging, where Nokia is a market leader.
- Nokia will help drive and define the future of Windows Phone. Nokia will contribute its expertise on hardware design, language support, and help bring Windows Phone to a larger range of price points, market segments and geographies.
- Nokia and Microsoft will closely collaborate on development, joint marketing initiatives and a shared development roadmap to align on the future evolution of mobile products.
- Bing will power Nokia's search services across Nokia devices and services, giving customers access to Bing's next generation search capabilities. Microsoft adCenter will provide search advertising services on Nokia's line of devices and services.
- Nokia Maps will be a core part of Microsoft's mapping services. For example, Maps would be integrated with Microsoft's Bing search engine and adCenter advertising platform to form a unique local search and advertising experience.
- Nokia's extensive operator billing agreements will make it easier for consumers to purchase Nokia Windows Phone services in countries where credit-card use is low.
- Microsoft development tools will be used to create applications to run on Nokia Windows Phones, allowing developers to easily leverage the ecosystem's global reach.
- Microsoft will continue to invest in the development of Windows Phone and cloud services so customers can do more with their phone, across their work and personal lives.

Nokia's content and application store will be integrated with Microsoft Marketplace for a more compelling consumer experience.

"Nokia and Microsoft will combine their strengths to deliver an ecosystem with unrivalled global reach and scale. It's now a three-horse race," Stephen Elop, Nokia's CEO, was quoted by Reuters, ahead of an investor day in London.

This gives a major shot in the arm to Windows Phone 7, which in spite of going through a complete overhaul, has failed to convince consumers or developers. Last reported, it had less than 2 per cent of the smartphone market. This deal will also open up a huge user base to its flagging search engine Bing.

In a private letter to employees, ahead of the Microsoft announcement, Nokia CEO Elop recognised Android as the major contributor to its shrinking sales numbers. He compared the company's situation to that of a man standing on a burning platform and wondering whether to jump in the icy waters to save his life. Quoting from Elop's letter, in 2008, Apple had 25 per cent market share of the \$300+ smartphone market. By 2010, this share had swollen to 61 per cent.

Gingerbread-powered OliveSmart launched in India

Indian handset maker Olive Telecom has launched a new Android-powered 3G smartphone, the 'OliveSmart V-S300', in association with Aircel. The phone runs on the Android 2.3 operating system (codenamed Gingerbread) and is claimed to be India's first HSPA+ smartphone. "This device promises to be a game changer with its rich looks and advanced features like 3G HSPA+, Android Gingerbread, Adobe Flash (10.1) and HD video. With our sizeable R&D investments, we are well-positioned to compete with the world's leading brands," said Arun Khanna, chairman of Olive Telecom.

The device sports a 10.4 cm (4.1") multi-touch capacitive touchscreen and a 5 megapixel camera with flash and auto-focus. Aimed at young professionals, the HSPA+ phone offers download and upload speeds of 14.4 MBps and 5.76 MBps, respectively.

Powered by Qualcomm's Snapdragon MSM8255 processor, the OliveSmart V-S300 comes in a slim body at 9.9 mm and includes Wi-Fi connectivity, a front camera, an accelerometer, digital compass, Google Maps, Live TV, an e-book reader, document reader and editor, Bluetooth 2.1 and 32 GB of expandable memory.

Khanna further added, "We are pleased to introduce a breakthrough convergence device which is more than a conventional smartphone and offers cutting-edge services that will appeal to generation-Y."

"Aircel is delighted to enter into a preferred partnership with Olive wherein Olive customers will enjoy exclusive data plans and a rich bouquet of content and value added services," shared Gurdeep Singh, COO, Aircel.

The phone comes with a price tag of Rs 20,000 (approx.). However, the company has not disclosed the availability date for the smartphone, as yet.